On 7 December 1993, he was rushed to the private ‘Clinica Las Condes’ in Santiago after fainting – doctors installed a pacemaker. For the next six months, he was worn out, apathetic towards his surroundings and sleeping for long periods. As the cancer progressed, the situation looked grave. Furthermore, Honecker did not bother the hospital with his presence again as he prepared himself for his demise. On 25 May, his doctor, Renato Palma, confirmed he turned down a last-minute operation as ‘hopeless’.

Finally, the end for Erich Paul Honecker came at 7 am on 29 May 1994 at ‘House G’ on Carlos Silva Vildósola in the presence of his wife and daughter. Ever stoic, Margot held his hand. She later telephoned the news to her lawyers in Berlin to get the word out. Telegrams of condolence came from staunch friends, including North Korea’s Kim Il-sung, who recalled Honecker actively supported the Korean people in the cause of socialist construction and national reunification: ‘The exploits he performed in his lifetime would remain forever.’12

Over in Bonn, Helmut Kohl’s spokesman, Dieter Vogel, stepped forward to declare Honecker had failed in his political goals. ‘His policies caused pain to countless people in Germany. Respect in the face of death requires that we say very little at this time about his role in post-war German history.’

Respect was the last thing German TV commentator Juergen Engert showed when describing Honecker as ‘a small figure who will turn out to be nothing more than a footnote in history. But what he did and didn’t do will keep us busy for a very long time to come.’ Neue Zeit opined that he represented a state in which very few people had confidence. ‘He was not the GDR, and the GDR was not Honecker.’ In a blistering editorial, the Irish Independent asserted the verdict of historians throughout the world would be a harsh one. ‘Erich Honecker imprisoned his own nation. As an epitaph, it is one few people would care to leave behind them.’

Finally, after funeral arrangements were decided, 3,000 people gathered in the summer heat at Honecker’s cremation at Santiago’s General Cemetery on Monday, 30 May. Around the open casket, wreaths from friends, neighbours and the German Communist Party were carefully spread out. Margot sat without a glance to either side. ‘He did not want a funeral in his